Ch15 edit, section 1 of 5: The zing

Editing runs/ch15/refined.md (not yet landed). Text in **bold** is new. Text marked ~~struck~~ comes out. Every new line is in your words from the interview, Round 1.

The zing. My family has a word for that kind of comment. We call it a zing, and there are so many in a day it's hard to keep count. A zing is a little slight, a cutting remark. It's a critique, only small.

I didn't handle them well. Every little critique from her was met with an equal or escalated response. I had no patience, I didn't let things go, I wasn't kind. **Frankly, neither was she.**

~~Answering back made sense, the way most habits do: you use what rewards.~~ **Arguing styles drift over time, almost like evolution.**

You use what rewards. I'd feel tired. I'd feel frustrated that immediately she was giving me things to do. Her words felt like she was calling me lazy. **And the ironic part is that it wasn't about any one topic. I was fed up with how we argued.**

You know that pull. You're worn out, the comment stings, and answering it feels like the natural thing to do. What changed for me came slowly, through experience. ~~I started asking who has the strength to de-escalate.~~ **I started asking: who has the strength to de-escalate? Somebody has to be calm. Somebody has to be patient. Somebody has to be the one who brings the warmth.**

We have a saying in our house: "Never be the worst part of somebody's day." It's a spot check, a way to make sure we're not unkind. It's also the reason not to send a zing back. A sharper answer is the quickest way to be the worst part of her day.

Three questions

1. **“Frankly, neither was she.”** OK to print? It’s honest, and it makes the rest of the chapter your choice, not her fault. The cost: she reads it.
2. **“You use what rewards.”** With “evolution” in front of it, it reads as: the style that wins in the moment is the one that survives. Is that what you meant? If you’d rather name the reward, give me a few words (for example “winning the exchange”).
3. **“Somebody has to be...”** I trimmed your four lines to three (“romantic and kind” is left out, since the chapter gets to kindness later). Keep it to three, or put the fourth back?

Reply “yes” to take it as shown, or give me your changes.